

GENJI

DAYS OF THE BLADE



Rating: 6/10
Developer: Game Republic
Publisher: SCE
Platform: PS3
Distributor: Milestone Interactive

Ancient Japan Never Looked So Good...

Genji is another of those save-ancient-Japan-from-the-evil-demon-lord games; this one is based on the old legend of Gaimaru Yoshitsune, a Samurai warrior, and his battle against the Heishi clan, who have solicited an assortment of demons to help them go about their evil deeds. Beyond that, *Genji's* story is marvellously incomprehensible.

You start as Yoshitsune, and once you meet the rest of the characters in the game, you can switch to any of them when you feel like it. Each warrior has a different fighting style, and they come with their own strengths and weaknesses. Yoshitsune has the best balance between agility and destructive power; Benkei is slow and lumbering, but dishes out fatal damage to many enemies with a single blow; Shizuka (the mandatory scantily-clad-butt-kicking-babe) is weak, but her grappling-hook-like weapon can attack enemies from a distance.

Aside from the beautifully rendered environments and brilliant sound, the game is generally unremarkable, but the combat won't disappoint. Combo moves can be devastating when done right, and you'll be kept on your toes with swarms of enemies, none of whom respect the "attack one by one" rule that they do in movies.

When you're not doing battle, you'll have environmental puzzles to solve, and this is the most frustrating part of the game. The camera angle is fixed, so you can't survey your surroundings properly, which makes it that much harder to find important hints or items.

In the end, *Genji* isn't a must-have game, but it does serve as an example of a well-executed one.

Fun In The Mud

Think of *MotorStorm* as something like *Monster Truck Madness*, only much, much better. Your sole duty is to race a variety of vehicles—dirt buggies, big rigs, motorcycles, and everything in between—around Monument Valley in the US, and try to enjoy the scenery while you're at it. The game's graphics are amazing—vehicles are immaculately detailed, and damage modelling is quite impressive. While you drive around the dirt tracks, your car / truck / whatever will continuously get plastered with mud and muck, and the overall effect is far better than what we've seen in off-road titles thus far. Locations are wonderfully rendered, and it's worth taking a plunge over the side just to admire the scenery. When you're not dropping off the side, the tracks are quite challenging, too.

MotorStorm's arcade-style gameplay is pure fun, and we love the number of ways you can blow up your vehicle. Bouncing around the track too much? Kablooeey. Take a cliff-side corner too fast? Soar... (wheel!)... kablooeey. Run into the wreckage of a kablooeey-ed opponent? Kablooeey. Too much boost? Kablooeey! It almost makes it worth not winning a race. The game's concept is much like any other—win races to unlock new

vehicles and tracks, and eventually collect them all. You don't, however, get to choose your class of vehicle—this is probably the game's way of ensuring that you're either (a) not going to stick to classes you're good at, or (b) forced try out every vehicle type—take your pick based on whether you like this feature or not.

One of the more interesting parts of *MotorStorm* is the ability to use the SIXAXIS controller as a steering wheel in the air. While fun, it was a little raw in the preview copy we were playing, with no sensitivity adjustment, but the retail version will let you tweak this. We expect it to be much better then.



Rating: 7/10
Developer: Evolution Studios
Publisher: SCE
Distributor: Milestone Interactive